

PATREON

/ APPLE IAP

STRUCTURAL DIAGNOSIS

Host-Constrained Primitive Mismatch — from publicly observable evidence.

“Patreon is not facing a billing migration. It is being forced to translate creator-defined patronage into Apple’s subscription grammar. That translation changes what Patreon is.”

ARTIFACT FAMILY

#	ARTIFACT	ACCESS
01	Translation Artifact	Public
02	Diagnostic Artifact	← <i>This document</i>
03	Redesign Executive Summary	Public
04	Redesign Artifact — Path A	Restricted
05	Redesign Artifact — Path B	Restricted

EVIDENTIARY STANDARD	JUDGMENT BOUNDARY
This artifact distinguishes directly evidenced facts [A][B], convergent public symptom patterns [C], consequence evidence [D], and structural inference [E]. The governing diagnosis is a structural inference derived from convergent public evidence and a defined diagnostic framework. It is not a claim about internal intent at Patreon or Apple.	This artifact makes no claim about intentional deception, fraud, or bad faith by Patreon or Apple. The mismatch described is consistent with structural incompatibility between two independently developed systems. No inference is made about internal decisions, undisclosed engineering choices, or adjudicated legal liability.
Evidence-class discipline: [C] sources are convergent symptom evidence — not proof of any individual event. [D] sources are consequence evidence and, where legal proceedings remain unresolved, allegation-level evidence only. [E] marks structural inference derived from convergence across public evidence classes. No single complaint, creator post, or legal filing is treated as sufficient proof.	What this artifact does not say: It does not claim Patreon or Apple acted in bad faith. It does not claim adjudicated liability. It does not claim access to internal engineering decisions or proprietary systems. It does not evaluate commercial fairness. It does not prescribe a specific technology solution. It does not say the mismatch was intentional.

SECTION 0

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS

This artifact is a structural diagnosis of the payment architecture conflict between Patreon's founding economic primitive and Apple's iOS in-app purchase system. It names the governing primitive, locates the first structural break, identifies the hidden burden carriers, and establishes the correction prerequisite. It does not evaluate redesign directions or propose solutions.

It is produced from publicly available materials only. All structural inferences are marked as such. The governing diagnosis is derived from convergent public evidence and the application of a defined diagnostic framework.

THIS ARTIFACT IS	THIS ARTIFACT IS NOT
A structural diagnosis from public evidence [A–E]	A legal brief, complaint, or regulatory filing
An identification of the primitive mismatch and first break	A moral judgment about Patreon or Apple
An establishment of the correction prerequisite	A redesign specification or solution proposal
A foundation for two distinct redesign directions	A claim about internal intent at either company
A public exemplar of the structural diagnostic method	A commissioned or authorised document

SECTION 0.1

DIAGNOSTIC SPINE

The ten-row governing summary. Every section of this artifact either leads toward row 4 or flows from it.

DIAGNOSTIC ELEMENT	FINDING
--------------------	---------

Governing primitive	Relationship-coded patronage economics: fans support creators on creator-defined terms, linked to the creative act, bounded by fan choice. This is the founding economic object Patreon was built to hold.
Stated promise	Fans fund creators on creator-defined terms. Billing events reflect the creative act — per-creation when creators publish, or subscription when both parties prefer it.
Actual operating object	Host-conditioned subscription-compatible payment events at the iOS boundary. Apple's IAP grammar governs payment initiation, refund authority, and remittance timeline. The creator's billing grammar is not representable inside Apple's payment system.
First structural break	The Primitive Switch: the moment a fan taps "Join" inside the Patreon iOS app. Support intent must become an Apple-governed purchase event. Per-creation logic is not representable. The patronage object is bypassed.
Function collapse	Transaction-state sensing and payment authority are externalised to Apple, while entitlement consequence remains downstream in Patreon's system. Apple detects non-compliance and enforces IAP rules through a host-governed process in which Patreon has no unilateral authority to preserve its native billing primitive. Interpretation is fragmented across three non-unified parties.
Missing function	Faithful economic translation of creator-defined patronage at the iOS boundary. No mechanism currently exists that preserves the per-creation relationship inside Apple's IAP grammar without structural loss.
Hidden burden carriers	Creators (communication, price-explanation, fan-routing); off-platform instruction layer (Discord, Twitter, community posts); Patreon 1:1 support team (manual migration); legal and policy teams.
Correction prerequisite	Formal internal declaration that the problem is a primitive mismatch, not a billing migration. This acknowledgment must precede all redesign scoping. Without it, every subsequent engineering decision will be framed as compliance improvement and will fail at the boundary unchanged.
Minimum redesign question	Preserve bilateral patronage through an economic translation layer (Direction A — The Decoupler), or restructure Patreon into a platform-level allocation system (Direction B — The Allocation Shift). These are not variants. They describe different futures for what Patreon is.
Proof condition	Same pressure → different response: a fan's support intent yields an economic outcome equivalent to pre-Apple per-creation terms, without creator ghost labour, billing compression, or host recapture. The redesign is real only when the patronage relationship survives the iOS boundary unchanged.

SECTION 0.2

PLAIN-LANGUAGE GLOSSARY

Technical terms used in this artifact, defined for non-specialist readers.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
------	---------------

Primitive Switch	The moment a fan's intent to support a creator — a relationship event — must become a payment event inside Apple's governed purchase system. The patronage object is bypassed at this moment.
Host-Constrained Primitive Mismatch	The structural class this failure belongs to: a platform's native economic primitive cannot be expressed inside the governing interface of its host platform without structural loss.
Creator-defined patronage object	The immutable contract between creator and fan: the fan supports the creator on creator-defined terms, linked to the creative act. If the payment rail modifies this object — as the multiplier does — the system has failed.
Value Leak	The financial exposure created when a creator delivers content against a commercial relationship that Apple has already terminated through a refund Patreon cannot yet detect. The creator carries delivery cost for a relationship that no longer exists.
Sensing Blind Spot	The interval between Apple processing a refund and Patreon detecting it through the remittance cycle. During this window, entitlement and payment status diverge. The creator cannot see it. Patreon cannot see it.
Refund Paradox	Apple governs the refund decision. Patreon governs the entitlement. The creator holds the delivery obligation. Three different parties govern three parts of the same commercial event.
Multiplier	Patreon's mechanism for converting per-creation billing into an Apple-compatible monthly subscription price. Takes the creator's maximum paid posts over the prior 3 months and uses that as a monthly equivalent. This is economic compression, not economic translation.
Ghost structure	The hidden human work — creator fan-routing posts, Discord guides, Patreon support team migrations — that the platform architecture should carry but does not. Load-bearing and invisible in operational costs.
Finality Clause	The governance rule that prevents simultaneous pursuit of both redesign directions. Engineering cannot build for both because attempting both is the structural condition that produced the current collapse.
Transaction-coded interface	Apple's IAP grammar: standardised recurring subscription events or one-time purchase events. Per-creation logic, output-linked billing, and fan-capped maximums have no representation in this grammar.

SECTION 1

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

GOVERNING DIAGNOSIS

Patreon is not migrating billing models. It is being forced to translate its founding economic primitive into Apple's platform grammar — and the translation changes what Patreon is.

At the iOS payment boundary, Apple governs payment initiation, refund authority, and remittance timeline. Patreon does not. Every visible problem — the 30% fee, the Refund Paradox, the external-browser friction, the multiplier, the off-platform instruction layer — is a downstream consequence of that authority shift, not a separate issue to be

solved individually.

The moment a fan taps “Join” inside the Patreon iOS app, the Primitive Switch occurs: the fan’s relationship-coded act of support must become a transaction-coded purchase event on Apple’s terms. Per-creation billing — where fans pay when a creator publishes, not on a monthly calendar — has no representation in Apple’s payment grammar at all.

Apple has changed its billing requirements three times in eighteen months. Each reversal forces Patreon to rebuild migration tooling, re-engage hundreds of thousands of creators, and spend the trust those creators built through their creative work. The problem is not execution. It is that Patreon’s founding economic grammar cannot be expressed inside Apple’s in-app purchase system.

Why prior fixes have not held: Patreon has tried to solve this at every layer except the one where it originates. It has proposed tools to Apple — all declined. It has built migration tooling, filed a formal complaint, published explanatory documentation, and watched its creators build an off-platform instruction layer to do the job the product cannot. When the product surface closes, the legal surface opens. When the legal surface is contested, creators build the ghost structure. None of this is a solution. It is all compensatory management of a condition that persists at the boundary unchanged.

Hidden burden: The platform’s apparent stability depends on creator labour — fan-routing posts, Discord guides, price-explanation communications — that is invisible in operational costs and unsustainable as a structural mechanism. When creators stop performing this function, the gap becomes a visible commercial failure for those who remain.

BOARD VERDICT

Board verdict: The patronage relationship Patreon signals and the transaction form the iOS boundary can safely instantiate are no longer the same object. Until that is named — not as a billing migration, but as a Host-Constrained Primitive Mismatch — every subsequent fix will be compensatory, and the same failure will return.

After reading this document, a decision-maker should be able to:

- State the primitive mismatch in one sentence
- Explain why prior fixes have not resolved the failure
- Distinguish between compensatory work and structural redesign
- Recognise the off-platform instruction layer as load-bearing ghost structure
- Demand that any proposed solution passes the Transfer Test: does it preserve the patronage relationship, or does it further compress it?

SECTION 2

ENGAGEMENT SCOPE

System under analysis: Patreon’s billing architecture and iOS monetisation surface — specifically the layer at which creator-fan payment relationships are initiated, processed, and enforced inside the iOS app, and the Apple IAP interface that governs what can occur at that boundary.

INSIDE SCOPE

OUTSIDE SCOPE

Patreon's three billing models and their operating logic	Content tooling, discovery features, community products
Creator-fan payment relationship — initiation, continuation, termination	Android and Google Play constraints
iOS app monetisation surface — where payment events are initiated	Patreon's internal team structure or individual decisions
Apple IAP interface — the grammar Patreon must satisfy	Apple's broader App Store policies beyond payment and billing
Entitlement enforcement — how payment state becomes access	Any claim about internal intent at Patreon or Apple
Refund handling — who holds authority over payment reversal	Assessment of commercial fairness or ethics
Web checkout surface (US only) and its contingent legal status	Patreon's legal strategy or litigation objectives

Evidence basis: Patreon Help Centre documentation, official creator blog posts and announcements, Apple Developer documentation, Epic v Apple legal proceedings (US District Court, 9th Circuit, April 2026 Supreme Court filings), TechCrunch, 9to5Mac, Macworld, documented creator testimony, and Patreon internal data as reported in third-party publications.

Timeframe: August 2024 through April 2026.

SECTION 3

FAILURE PATTERN RECONSTRUCTED FROM PUBLIC EVIDENCE

The following represents the operating problem as Patreon's own public record describes it — in the platform's language, before structural translation. All quotations are from Patreon's own official communications [A].

CLAIM TYPE	HOW THIS ARTIFACT TREATS IT
First-party Patreon / Apple statements [A][B]	Direct evidence of stated design and operating mechanics. Treated as the most reliable source class.
Creator reports [C]	Convergent symptom evidence. No individual report is treated as proof. Pattern across many sources is treated as structural signal.
Legal filings [D]	Allegation-level consequence evidence. Proceedings are unresolved. Claims treated as consistent with the structural diagnosis, not as proof of it.
Media and press reports [D]	Public consequence evidence. Corroborates the consequence layer. Not treated as primary structural proof.
Structural diagnosis [E]	Inference from convergence across all source classes. Clearly marked [E]. Not a claim about internal intent or undisclosed systems.

Patreon's own language [A]:

“Apple’s in-app purchase system only supports creators on subscription billing.”

“We strongly disagree with this decision. Creators need consistency and clarity in order to build healthy, long-term businesses. Instead, creators using legacy billing will now have to endure the whiplash of another policy reversal — the third such change from Apple in the past 18 months.”

“Late last year, they blocked a Patreon app update and made it clear that in order to remain in the App Store, we have to comply with their billing requirement.”

“Over the years, we have proposed multiple tools and features to Apple that we could’ve built to allow creators using legacy billing to transition on their own timelines. Unfortunately, Apple has continually declined them.”

Structural observation [E]: Patreon’s own language describes a recurring failure — three reversals, creator trust spent, tools proposed and declined — while framing the problem as external compliance. The structural translation that follows moves from this surface framing to the layer beneath it.

SECTION 4

EARLY STRUCTURAL SIGNALS

SIGNAL	EVIDENCE CLASS	STRUCTURAL SIGNIFICANCE
Multiple payment geometries against one membership object	[E] from [A]	Patreon now operates four structurally different payment rails against the same membership object. When a platform requires this many geometries to hold one commercial relationship coherent, the architecture has fractured at the primitive level.
Multiplier requires 1:1 support — self-serve unavailable	[A] direct	When a platform cannot automate a translation between two of its own billing models, the translation is not a formatting problem. It is a primitive conflict.
Legal surface has opened	[D] direct	Formal complaints are evidence that the constraint now exceeds unilateral product authority. Patreon can manage consequences through product work but cannot change Apple’s interface grammar without Apple consent or legal change.
Off-platform instruction layer has formed	[C] convergent	Discord servers, Twitter threads, and creator community posts teach fans to bypass the iOS app. This is not creator creativity. It is compensatory infrastructure that formed because the product cannot perform a function the commercial relationship requires.
Legal foundation of interim fix is contested	[D] direct	Web checkout depends on the Epic v Apple ruling. Apple’s motion to stay was granted April 6, 2026. Supreme Court bid filed. The interim architecture is contingent.
4% legacy figure understates diagnostic significance	[E] inference	The remaining legacy creators preserve the clearest surviving trace of Patreon’s original economic primitive. Their small number does not reduce their diagnostic value. They are the part of the system where the patronage grammar is still visible enough to expose the mismatch with full clarity.

SECTION 4.1

COMMON MISDIAGNOSES

Each of the following explanations is visible in public discourse. Each addresses a real symptom. None reaches the structural cause.

MISDIAGNOSIS	WHY IT IS INSUFFICIENT
Apple's 30% fee is the problem	The fee is downstream of Apple governing the payment event. The primitive mismatch would persist even at 0% because per-creation billing cannot be represented in Apple's IAP grammar at all. Fee reduction does not restore the patronage relationship.
Poor migration communication	Three policy reversals in 18 months are structural evidence, not a messaging failure. Communication management of structural instability is ghost work. More communication does not change what Apple's IAP grammar can represent.
Technical compliance gap	Patreon proposed multiple tools to Apple. All were declined. A technical gap would be expected to yield at least one accepted proposal. Consistent rejection suggests the constraint is not resolvable at the tooling layer.
Creator resistance to change	Per-creation migration requires 1:1 support from Patreon's product team because the transformation cannot be automated. That is a primitive conflict, not change management resistance.
Epic ruling will fix it	The ruling is under Supreme Court review. Even if upheld, it only enables web checkout for US fans — which breaks impulse support, introduces friction, and is unavailable internationally. It does not change Apple's IAP grammar.
App Store policy dispute	Policy is the host expression of the deeper structural condition: Patreon's economic object cannot be faithfully represented inside the host grammar. Winning a policy dispute does not resolve the primitive incompatibility.

SECTION 4.5

HUMAN SURFACE OF THE PRIMITIVE MISMATCH

Josh 'Cheeseness' Bush suspended billing and cancelled memberships in public protest in January 2026, after eighteen months of documented correspondence with Patreon in which the structural rationale for the migration was never explained in a way that preserved his economic relationship with his community [C].

This is not an edge case. It is the human surface of the primitive mismatch — the point where a structural failure becomes a commercial and relational event in a creator's life. The creator cannot recover trust that was spent on repeated policy reversals. The community cannot recover the original patronage relationship once the billing event has been severed from the creative act.

The structural reading of this event: a creator who built their community on the premise that fans pay when they publish — and only when they publish — was told that this economic relationship cannot be held at the iOS boundary. The migration tooling did not preserve the relationship. It replaced it with a subscription-compatible approximation. That is the Primitive Switch made visible at the creator-fan layer.

SECTION 5

SYSTEM BOUNDARY AND TOPOLOGY

Primary actors and authority at iOS boundary [A][B]:

NODE	ROLE	AUTHORITY AT iOS BOUNDARY
Fan	Payment principal; support intent originator	None over billing grammar or refund outcomes
Creator	Revenue-dependent; defines desired billing model	None over iOS payment processing or refund decisions
Patreon	Platform intermediary; entitlement enforcer; web payment processor	Full authority on web; conditional on Apple's permission on iOS
Apple	Host platform; IAP gatekeeper; refund and remittance authority	Decisive authority at iOS boundary

System topology — designed path vs actual path [E] from [A]:

PATH	SEQUENCE	CONSEQUENCE
Designed path	Fan intent → Patreon patronage object → entitlement resolution A→B→D	Fan intent enters Patreon's system. Patreon holds the patronage relationship. Entitlement is resolved from payment state.
Actual path under Apple constraint	Fan intent → Apple IAP transaction layer → entitlement resolution A → C → D	Fan intent enters Apple's IAP system directly. Node B (Patreon's patronage object) is bypassed at the payment initiation point. Entitlement is resolved from Apple's transaction output, not from Patreon's patronage object.
Distortion	Node B no longer governs the A→C transition	The patronage relationship exists inside Patreon's system but does not control the commercial event that initiates it. Apple controls that event. Patreon cannot recover authority over it through product action within Apple's current grammar.

SECTION 6

WORKFLOW AND PIPELINE TRACE

The actual operating sequence under Apple constraint: Comply → Migrate → Absorb → Survive

Trace A — Per-creation creator and new fan on iOS [A][B]:

- Fan discovers creator through YouTube, podcast, or social media. Forms intent to support.
- Fan taps “Join” inside the Patreon iOS app. The Primitive Switch occurs. Support intent must become a payment event Apple's IAP grammar can process.
- Apple IAP presents a monthly subscription price derived from Patreon's multiplier: the creator's maximum paid posts over the prior 3 months, converted to a monthly equivalent. Output cadence is ignored.
- Fan pays through Apple IAP. Apple takes approximately 30% commission. Remittance begins — typically approximately 45 days after month-end.
- Creator receives monthly subscription income regardless of whether they publish. The billing event is severed from the creative act.
- If the fan requests a refund, Apple governs the outcome. Creator may have delivered exclusive content against a commercial relationship Apple has already terminated. Creator's tier rules do not apply.
- Creator instructs other fans via Discord or social media to subscribe through web browser, using personal trust and communication channels to route around the product's structural failure.

Trace B — International fan [A][B]:

- Fan discovers creator and forms support intent.
- Fan taps “Join” inside iOS app. Apple IAP is the only available path. No web checkout exists for international fans. No structural remedy exists at any product layer currently available to Patreon.
- Apple takes approximately 30% commission. Creator must choose: increase iOS prices to preserve earnings, or absorb the fee and earn less. Either choice degrades the creator-fan relationship.
- Refund Paradox and Value Leak apply with no interim remedy of any kind.

The original per-creation workflow is structurally absent from both traces. Fan pays only when creator publishes, up to a fan-set monthly maximum — this economic object no longer exists at the iOS boundary.

SECTION 7

FUNCTIONAL DIAGNOSIS

Framework applied: The Four-Function Law — institutions fail under scale when sensing, interpretation, authority, and memory are misallocated or fused at the point of consequence [E].

FUNCTION	FORMAL LOCATION	ACTUAL LOCATION	CONDITION	CONSEQUENCE
Sensing	Patreon billing + Apple IAP	Split and degraded	Patreon cannot sense Apple's payment status during the remittance window. Entitlement and payment status may diverge during this gap.	Value Leak: creator delivers content against a relationship that may no longer exist [E from A/B]
Interpretation	Patreon + Apple + creators	Fragmented across three non-unified parties	Apple interprets its own rules unilaterally. Patreon interprets compliance. Creators interpret business impact. No single surface holds all three.	Documentation proliferation is the structural evidence [E from A]
Authority	Apple IAP (iOS); Patreon (web, entitlement)	Externalised and unequal	Apple governs payment initiation, refund decisions, and remittance at the iOS boundary. Patreon's authority is conditional on Apple's permission.	Patreon cannot close the Sensing Blind Spot through product action [A direct]
Memory	Creator billing patron records	Degraded for legacy economics	The subscription record created by multiplier migration does not preserve the output-linked history of the original per-creation contract.	Per-creation economic relationship is lost at migration [E from A]

CRITICAL FUNCTION FUSION

Governing functional distortion [E]: Transaction-state sensing and payment authority are externalised to Apple at the iOS boundary, while entitlement consequence remains downstream in Patreon’s system. Apple detects non-compliance and enforces IAP rules through a host-governed process in which Patreon has no unilateral authority to preserve its native billing primitive. An authority layer acting on externally controlled sensing, without separation between the two, produces systematic distortion as a structural output — not as an occasional error.

DIAGNOSTIC LAW [E]

DIAGNOSTIC LAW — HOST-CONSTRAINED PRIMITIVE MISMATCH: *A relationship-coded economic system cannot be faithfully executed inside a transaction-coded payment interface without structural loss. Patreon is a direct instance of this law. The loss is not a fee, a refund, or a communication failure. It is the systematic substitution of one economic object for another at the point of payment initiation.*

SECTION 8

FIRST STRUCTURAL BREAK

The Primitive Switch at the support intent → payment initiation handoff inside iOS.

This is the moment a fan’s intent to support a specific creator — a relationship event, on that creator’s terms — must be expressed as a payment event inside Apple’s governed purchase surface. At that moment, the relationship-coded economic object must conform to Apple’s transaction-coded grammar. Per-creation logic is not representable. First-of-month logic is not representable. The creator’s chosen economic grammar is absent at the boundary.

Why every visible failure traces to this point [E]:

DOWNSTREAM SYMPTOM	TRACE TO PRIMITIVE SWITCH
30% Apple fee	Payment passes through Apple’s system, which became the governing system because Patreon’s billing grammar cannot satisfy Apple’s requirements at the boundary.
The multiplier	Per-creation economics cannot be expressed in Apple’s IAP grammar, which became operative because the Primitive Switch forced it.
Value Leak	Sensing is degraded during Apple’s remittance cycle, which became the operative cycle because payment authority moved to Apple.
Refund Paradox	Apple governs refund decisions, which became Apple’s authority because the payment event enters Apple’s system at the boundary.
Off-platform instruction layer	Creators cannot guide fans through an alternative path inside the app without violating Apple’s guidelines, which apply because the payment boundary is Apple’s.

Nothing downstream of the Primitive Switch can resolve it. Every fix downstream is compensatory management of a condition that persists at the boundary unchanged.

EVENT-BASED VS STATE-BASED [E]

Event-based versus state-based: Apple's IAP is event-based — a transaction either occurs or it does not. Patreon's patronage is state-based — an ongoing relationship between a specific fan and a specific creator that persists across time, output cadence, and billing periods. A state-based relationship cannot be managed through an event-based interface without structural loss. The loss is not incidental. It is definitional.

Evidence — all [A]: (1) “Apple’s in-app purchase system only supports creators on subscription billing.” (2) Per-creation migration requires 1:1 support — conversion cannot be automated. (3) “They blocked a Patreon app update and made it clear that in order to remain in the App Store, we have to comply.” (4) Patreon proposed multiple tools to Apple. Apple declined all of them. [Structural inference from Tier A evidence: consistent rejection suggests the constraint is not resolvable at the tooling layer.]

SECTION 9

COMPENSATION AND HIDDEN BURDEN

Sensing Blind Spot — admissible risk scenario [E from A/B]:

Based on documented remittance delay and refund authority mechanics. Exact timing varies by case. This scenario is illustrative; actual outcomes depend on refund timing, entitlement mechanics, and content delivery cadence.

DAY	EVENT	WHO KNOWS
Day 0	Fan subscribes on iOS. Pays £10. Apple takes £3. Creator begins delivering exclusive content.	Patreon + Creator
Day 2	Fan requests refund through Apple. Apple approves it. Fan receives £10 back.	Apple only
Days 2–45	Creator delivers second and third exclusive posts. Refund is processed and complete.	Creator and Patreon do not know refund occurred
Day 45+	Apple remittance cycle closes. Patreon learns the payment was refunded.	Patreon learns. Creator learns.
Outcome	Creator has delivered exclusive content across the window. Creator earns nothing from this subscription. Fan consumed the content. Patreon cannot recover the access already granted.	Creator carries delivery cost

Ghost Structure Burden Carrier Map [A][C][E]:

The creator becomes the routing layer for a product boundary Patreon no longer controls. When creators stop performing this function — because they leave, burn out, or migrate — the structural gap it fills becomes a visible commercial failure for the creators who remain.

CARRIER	CURRENT BURDEN	LEADING INDICATOR	MIGRATION SIGNAL
---------	----------------	-------------------	------------------

Creators — communication burden	When Apple changes requirements, creators communicate policy changes to fan communities through their own channels, spending trust built through creative work. Each reversal spends that trust.	Number of creator posts instructing fans to bypass iOS app	Creator stops needing to post “sign up on web”
Creators — price-explanation burden	Patreon publishes a help article for creators to share with fans explaining why iOS prices are higher. The structural cost of Apple’s fee is communicated at the creator-fan relationship layer.	Creator-reported time spent explaining iOS pricing	Fan confusion about pricing falls without creator explanation
Off-platform instruction layer	Discord servers, Twitter threads, and community posts where creators teach fans to bypass the iOS app. Load-bearing. Invisible in Patreon’s operational costs. Sustained entirely by creator labour and relational capital.	Volume of external routing instructions	External routing posts no longer necessary for fan onboarding
Patreon 1:1 support team	Every per-creation migration requires direct product team support. Self-serve unavailable. Capacity finite. Load set by Apple’s deadline, not Patreon’s roadmap.	Hours per migration; backlog size; failure rate	Self-serve migration becomes available

SECTION 10

GOVERNING DIAGNOSIS

Structural inference derived from convergent Tier A through Tier D evidence and the application of the diagnostic framework. Not a claim about internal intent at Patreon or Apple.

Patreon’s recurring billing crisis is not best explained as a migration management problem, a creator communication failure, or a technical compliance gap. The structural reading is this:

Patreon was founded on the premise that the billing event and the creative act are economically linked — that fans pay when creators publish, on terms the creator and fan define together, and that the platform’s job is to hold that relationship coherently. Apple’s in-app purchase system was built on a structurally different premise: that digital goods are sold through standardised recurring subscription events, processed through Apple’s payment infrastructure, governed by Apple’s billing grammar, refunded and remitted on Apple’s timeline. These two premises are incompatible at the primitive level. They describe different economic objects.

At the moment a fan taps “Join” inside the Patreon iOS app, the Primitive Switch occurs. The patronage relationship — built between a specific fan and a specific creator on creator-defined terms — must become a payment event Apple’s IAP grammar can process. At that moment, Apple governs the payment initiation, the refund authority, and the remittance timeline. The creator governs none of them.

DIMENSION	STATED — PATREON'S PROMISE	ACTUAL — UNDER iOS IAP
What triggers billing	Creative act (per-creation) or calendar (subscription), creator's choice	Apple-compatible subscription interval, regardless of creative output
Who governs the commercial event	Patreon and creator	Apple (payment initiation, refund, remittance)
Fan-creator relationship	Bilateral, direct, on creator's terms	Triangulated through Apple's payment grammar
Per-creation economics	Supported as first-class primitive	Structurally absent — must be compressed into subscription via multiplier
Refund authority	Creator's rules apply	Apple decides unilaterally; creator not consulted
Remittance timeline	Patreon's typical monthly cycle	45–75 days after month-end; sensing gap active during this window

STRONGEST FALSIFIER — SECTION 10

Strongest falsifier: if Patreon separates payment initiation grammar from patronage object logic, restores per-creation economics as first-class objects, separates sensing from authority at the iOS boundary, and closes the refund sensing gap — yet the same creator ghost labour, billing compression, and value leak pattern persists under comparable usage — the diagnosis must be revised.

PROOF STANDARD

PROOF STANDARD: Same pressure → different response. The redesign is real only when a fan's support intent yields an economic outcome equivalent to pre-Apple per-creation terms — without creator ghost labour, billing compression, or host recapture. Until that condition holds, the primitive mismatch persists regardless of what the product roadmap claims.

SECTION 10A

FAILURE CLASS

HOST-CONSTRAINED PRIMITIVE MISMATCH — FAILURE CLASS DEFINITION

Host-Constrained Primitive Mismatch: a system enters this failure class when its core economic or coordination primitive cannot be expressed in the governing interface of its host platform without structural loss. The conditions that define the class: (1) A platform has a native economic primitive — a specific form of value exchange it was built to hold. (2) A host platform controls the interface through which that value exchange must be commercially initiated. (3) The host platform's interface grammar is incompatible with the native primitive. (4) The platform cannot replace the host without losing access to the population or surface the host controls.

Structural consequences that do not vary by domain [E]:

- Authority over the commercial event shifts to the host
- The platform's internal logic becomes compensatory relative to the host's grammar
- Every corrective action that does not name the primitive conflict will fail at the interface and produce burden at adjacent layers
- Ghost structures form to carry the functions the product can no longer perform at the boundary
- Failure repeats regardless of local optimisation

KNOWN INSTANCE	NATIVE PRIMITIVE	HOST CONSTRAINT
Patreon under Apple IAP (this artifact)	Relationship-coded patronage economics	Apple IAP subscription-only grammar
Spotify under Apple App Store [D]	Music streaming subscription at platform-set price	Apple IAP commission and price-control terms
Amazon Kindle under Apple IAP [D]	Digital book purchase without IAP commission	Apple IAP in-app purchase requirement history

Implication for redesign: The Redesign Artifacts must specify a solution that either (a) separates the native primitive from the host interface so the host sees only a compatible form, or (b) replaces the host interface entirely. No solution that operates within the current interface grammar without architectural separation will exit the failure class.

SECTION 11

COST OF CONTINUATION

COST CATEGORY	MECHANISM	EVIDENCE CLASS
Creator trust erosion	Each policy reversal spends creator trust that cannot be recovered. Competitor platforms are commercially exploiting the instability.	[C] Passion.io exodus narrative; SchoolMaker and Medium migration guides
Category definition loss	Every creator post instructing fans to "sign up on the web" is a measurable instance of Patreon losing its definition as frictionless membership infrastructure. This is the gradual compression of what Patreon means.	[E] from [C] convergent
Per-creation economic compression	Every creator migrated under the multiplier has had their economic relationship with fans changed at its root. Billing severs from creation. The social contract that made Patreon distinct is broken at the billing layer.	[A] Help Centre; [E] structural inference
Value Leak — active financial exposure	The Sensing Blind Spot scenario in Section 9 illustrates a structural consequence of the remittance lag operating alongside Apple's refund authority. The creator bears delivery obligation for a relationship the platform cannot yet confirm is active.	[A][B] remittance and refund docs; [E] inference
iOS conversion degradation	External-browser web checkout breaks impulse support economics at Patreon's highest-value acquisition surface. International fans have no alternative path.	[E] from [A] mechanics

Legal uncertainty compounding	Web checkout option for US fans is contingent on the Epic ruling under Supreme Court review. Apple's stay was granted April 6, 2026. If the ruling reverses, the last structural remedy disappears.	[D] direct — Epic v Apple filings
Engineering capacity locked to compliance	Publicly visible product work has included repeated compliance iterations: multiplier, repricing tools, web checkout, external browser migration. The opportunity cost is visible in the public product timeline.	[E] from [A] timeline
Patron churn amplification	Patreon internal data (April 2024, reported by Passion.io): 21% patron cancellation rate, 12% average decline rate. Note: Tier C — competitor-reported, 18-month-old internal data; treat as directional signal, not confirmed figure.	[C] Passion.io — treat as directional only

Compounding dynamic — no internal exit without primitive correction [E]:

STAGE	MECHANISM	STRUCTURAL ORIGIN
1	Apple changes IAP policy or enforcement	Host platform unilateral authority
2	Patreon builds migration and compliance tooling	Compensatory response to host grammar change
3	Creator trust erodes; migration instability visible	Economic relationship changed without consent
4	Off-platform instruction layer forms and grows	Product cannot route around constraint
5	Engineering capacity locked to compliance iterations	Opportunity cost; no creator innovation capacity
6	Competitors exploit platform instability	Category definition loss
7	Legal surface opens — formal complaint filed	Product surface no longer sufficient to preserve native primitive
8	Return to Stage 1 (next policy change)	No internal exit without primitive correction

SECTION 12

CORRECTION PREREQUISITE AND REDESIGN DIRECTION BOUNDARY

Immediate refusals — the Vanish List:

STOP	REASON
Treating the multiplier as economic translation	It is economic compression. It changes the relationship it claims to preserve. Building on it as a valid translation layer is building on misrepresentation.
Positioning web checkout in external browser as a structural fix	It is a partial fee-avoidance mechanism for US fans, contingent on an unstable legal ruling, that breaks impulse support at the highest-value acquisition surface.

Treating each Apple policy reversal as a communication problem	Three reversals in 18 months are structural evidence of incompatible goals. Communication management of structural instability is ghost work, not a fix.
Designing against the Epic ruling as a stable foundation	The Supreme Court case is active. The stay is granted. The interim architecture is contingent. Build decisions must not depend on this ruling holding.
Auto-migrating remaining legacy creators under the current multiplier	Every creator migrated under this logic loses the economic relationship their community was built on. This is active structural harm. Pause until a genuine translation layer is specified.

First move — prerequisite for everything that follows:

Formally declare the governing diagnosis internally. The problem is not a compliance migration. The founding economic primitive cannot be expressed inside Apple's IAP grammar at the iOS boundary. This acknowledgment must precede all redesign scoping. **Owner:** CEO and executive leadership. **Risk if skipped:** all subsequent moves replicate the current mismatch in a more expensive form.

Two redesign directions — high-level summary only:

Two structurally distinct exits from the mismatch exist. They are not variants of the same solution. They describe different futures for what Patreon is. The choice is a strategic decision for leadership, not a product or engineering decision. Full specification of both directions is contained in the Redesign Artifacts.

DIRECTION	WHAT IT IS	SUCCESS CONDITION
Direction A — The Decoupler	Patreon holds creator-defined patronage relationships as first-class objects inside its own system. It generates subscription-compatible payment events at the Apple interface as a derived output. Apple sees a subscription. Patreon's system holds the patronage economics behind it.	A fan joins a per-creation creator's iOS membership, pays through Apple IAP, and the creator receives a net economic outcome structurally equivalent to the pre-Apple relationship — with output-linked logic preserved inside Patreon's system.
Direction B — The Allocation Shift	Fans hold one funding relationship with Patreon and distribute support across creators using their own allocation logic. Patreon is the payment entity Apple sees. Creator-defined economics are preserved inside the allocation layer, invisible to Apple's billing grammar.	A fan holds one subscription to Patreon, distributes support across creators using their own allocation logic, and each creator receives income on terms matching their production cadence — with Apple seeing only the single Patreon subscription.

THE FINALITY CLAUSE

THE FINALITY CLAUSE: A client implementation redesign cannot proceed until leadership selects Direction A or Direction B. Engineering cannot build for both simultaneously because attempting both is the structural condition that produced the current collapse — multiple payment geometries held against one membership object, with no coherent primitive governing any of them. The choice between Direction A and Direction B is a decision about what Patreon is. It cannot be delegated to product or engineering. For exemplar purposes, both directions are specified as separate replacement architectures in the Redesign Artifacts.

SECTION 13

ROLE-LEVEL DIAGNOSTIC IMPLICATIONS

Structural translation of the diagnosis into role-specific implications. Full technical spikes and implementation actions belong in the Redesign Artifacts.

ROLE	DIAGNOSTIC IMPLICATION	MUST STOP ASSUMING	IMMEDIATE DIAGNOSTIC CHECK
CEO / Leadership	Primitive mismatch must be declared before any redesign. The compliance framing has closed the product surface. The choice between Direction A and Direction B is a strategic identity decision, not a product choice.	That compliance migration is the real problem. That the legal and product strategies can be pursued in parallel without coordinating their strategic function.	Has leadership formally stated that per-creation billing cannot be expressed inside Apple's IAP grammar?
CPO / Product	The multiplier is economic compression, not translation. Further investment in multiplier refinements is investment in the compression layer. Each redesign direction requires separate specification before evaluation.	That web checkout is a structural fix. That the current billing architecture can be extended into a valid translation layer.	Does the product roadmap still include multiplier refinements as a valid correction path?
Engineering	Two technical spikes are required — one per direction — before any build decision is made. The Sensing Blind Spot must be instrumented as operational data, not managed as a known limitation.	That the current billing architecture can be extended to hold per-creation logic. That the sensing gap is a known acceptable risk.	Is there monitoring for the interval between Apple refund and Patreon entitlement revocation?
Operations / Support	The off-platform instruction layer is structural signal, not customer noise. The 1:1 migration support burden is a measure of primitive conflict, not change management friction.	That creator posts instructing fans to bypass iOS are creative workarounds rather than structural evidence.	How many creators are actively instructing fans to bypass the iOS app? What is the migration backlog and hours-per-creator?
Legal / Policy	The formal complaint's strategic function must be explicitly defined and shared with product. Designing against the Epic ruling as a stable legal foundation is a planning error.	That legal and product strategies can be pursued simultaneously without explicit coordination on their respective objectives.	Is the complaint designed to change Apple's billing grammar, or to signal that the product surface is closed? These are different strategies with different product implications.

SECTION 14

EVIDENCE REFERENCE

Evidence tier key:

TI ER	CLASS	TREATMENT
----------	-------	-----------

[A]	First-party Patreon / Apple documentation	Highest weight. Establishes stated design, compliance position, and operating mechanics.
[B]	First-party operating signals	High weight. Establishes actual operating mechanics distinct from policy statements.
[C]	Public symptom evidence — creator testimony, press, competitors	Convergent pattern evidence. No individual source is treated as proof. Pattern treated as structural signal.
[D]	Legal and regulatory consequence evidence	Consequence evidence. Where proceedings are unresolved, treated as allegation-level only.
[E]	Structural inference	Derived from convergence across source classes and application of diagnostic framework. Clearly marked. Not a claim about internal intent.

Tier A — First-party Patreon documentation:

- Patreon Help Centre: “iOS In-app Purchases and Migrating to Subscription Billing FAQ” (March 2026). November 1, 2026 deadline. Multiplier mechanism. 1:1 support requirement. September 30 support cutoff.
- Patreon Help Centre: “How to move from per-creation to subscription billing” (March 2026). Per-creation migration requires direct team support — not self-serve.
- Patreon Help Centre: “How iOS in-app purchases work on Patreon.” Approximately 30% Apple fee. US web checkout under Epic ruling. Creator pricing choice.
- Patreon Help Centre: “iOS in-app purchases FAQ.” International fans cannot opt out of approximately 30% fee. Apple processes refunds. Remittance up to 75 days after transaction date.
- Patreon for Creators, January 28, 2026: Third policy reversal confirmed. Public disagreement stated. Apology for pausing transition.
- Patreon for Creators, May 2025: Epic ruling response. November 2025 deadline void. Apple instruction to move web checkout to external browser.

Tier B — First-party operating signals:

- iOS price markup: approximately 43% increase when creators choose to maintain earnings.
- Payment remittance: “can take up to 75 days after the transaction date.” Typical cycle approximately 45 days after month-end.
- Refund authority: “Apple will handle the refund on the creator’s behalf.”
- App update blockage: “they blocked a Patreon app update and made it clear that in order to remain in the App Store, we have to comply.”
- Tools proposed and declined: multiple tools proposed to Apple to preserve legacy billing flexibility; all declined.

Tier C — Public symptom evidence:

- Josh ‘Cheeseness’ Bush, Patreon (August 2024, updated January 2026): 18-month documented correspondence. Suspended billing. Cancelled memberships in protest January 30, 2026.
- Passion.io, November 2025: “Patreon Exodus” narrative. April 2024 internal data reported: 21% patron cancellation rate, 12% average decline rate. [Treat as directional only: Tier C, competitor-reported, 18-month-old internal data.]
- Competitor migration guides (2026): SchoolMaker, Passion.io, Medium — all citing Apple billing changes as migration trigger.
- Off-platform instruction layer: Convergent across creator Discord servers, Twitter threads, and direct fan communications.

Tier D — Legal and regulatory consequence evidence:

- Epic v Apple, US District Court, April 30, 2025: Court rules Apple cannot collect commissions on external payment links.
- US Court of Appeals for the Ninth Circuit, December 2025: Contempt finding upheld. Apple’s 27% external fee ruled excessive.
- Apple stay granted, April 6, 2026: Supreme Court bid filed. Web checkout option’s legal foundation explicitly under appeal.
- TechCrunch, January 28, 2026: Third policy reversal documented. Patreon’s public disagreement confirmed.
- 9to5Mac, Macworld, Appleosophy, AppleInsider (January 28, 2026): Convergent press coverage confirming structural condition.

SECTION 14.1

SOURCE REGISTER

Representative primary sources by evidence tier. Named specifically for verifiability.

TI ER	SOURCE	SPECIFIC ITEM	USED FOR
[A]	Patreon Help Centre (March 2026)	iOS IAP migration FAQ; subscription billing mandate; multiplier mechanism	Operating design, compliance position
[A]	Patreon for Creators blog (Jan 28, 2026)	Third policy reversal announcement; tools proposed and declined	Direct evidence of closed product surface
[A]	Patreon Help Centre — refund/remittance docs	75-day remittance maximum; Apple refund authority; fan-creator fee mechanics	Sensing Blind Spot and Value Leak foundation
[A]	Patreon Help Centre — per-creation billing	Operating logic of per-creation model; monthly maximum; patron access rules	Original patronage primitive definition
[A]	Patreon for Creators blog (May 2025)	Epic ruling response; external browser migration instruction	Interim fix mechanics and contingency
[B]	Apple Developer documentation	IAP grammar; subscription-only billing rules; refund handling	Host platform constraint specification
[C]	Josh ‘Cheeseness’ Bush public posts (Aug 2024, Jan 2026)	18-month documented correspondence; public membership cancellation protest	Human surface of the primitive mismatch
[C]	Passion.io (Nov 2025)	“Patreon Exodus”; reported April 2024 internal churn data	Competitor-reported symptom evidence — directional only
[C]	SchoolMaker / Medium migration guides (2026)	Migration rationale citing Apple billing changes as trigger	Category definition loss symptom evidence
[C]	Creator Discord / Twitter (convergent, 2024–2026)	Off-platform fan-routing instructions; bypass guides	Ghost structure / off-platform instruction layer

[D]	Epic v Apple, US District Court (Apr 30, 2025)	External payment link ruling; Patreon named as implementing developer	Legal foundation of US web checkout
[D]	9th Circuit, December 2025	Contempt finding upheld; 27% external fee ruled excessive	Legal consequence evidence
[D]	Apple stay granted, April 6, 2026	Supreme Court bid filed; web checkout foundation under appeal	Contingency risk of interim fix
[D]	TechCrunch (Jan 28, 2026)	Third reversal documented; Patreon's public disagreement	Public consequence evidence
[E]	Four-Function Law (Forrester 2026b)	Diagnostic framework applied in Section 7	Structural inference framework — not independently evidenced

APPENDIX A

LIVE ENGAGEMENT DIAGNOSTIC ACCEPTANCE PROTOCOL

ACCEPTANCE PROTOCOL

DIAGNOSTIC ACCEPTANCE PROTOCOL (BINDING) This is the protocol used in live engagements. Within 14 calendar days of receiving this Diagnostic Artifact, the commissioning leadership team must return a signed copy of the acceptance checklist below. In live engagements, the Redesign Artifact is only offered after explicit acceptance of the governing diagnosis or a substantive written structural counter-argument. Without that acceptance, the diagnostic engagement closes and no redesign sequence begins. Fees paid to date are non-refundable. In this public exemplar, the client and organisation fields are left unpopulated. The checklist, consequence clause, and signature blocks are reproduced in full. The protocol is identical to what any commissioning client signs. This document was not commissioned by Patreon or Apple.

Acceptance checklist:

ITEM	ACCEPTANCE CONDITION
■ Primitive mismatch acknowledged	Leadership confirms: Patreon's founding economic grammar cannot be expressed inside Apple's IAP system at the iOS boundary. This acknowledgment is the prerequisite for every subsequent move.
■ Vanish List agreed	The five Non-Negotiable Refusal Conditions in Section 12 are stopped. No further auto-migration under the current multiplier; web checkout not positioned as structural fix; Epic ruling not treated as stable foundation.
■ Dependency order accepted	The primitive declaration (Move 1) precedes all redesign scoping. No engineering work begins on either direction until the governing diagnosis is accepted.
■ Finality Clause accepted	Direction A (Decoupler) or Direction B (Allocation Shift) will be selected before build specification begins. Both directions will be separately specified. They will not be built simultaneously.

■ Redesign Artifact commissioned	The Redesign Artifact (one per direction, or one per leadership's selected direction) is formally commissioned as the next engagement.
■ Measurement baseline established	Off-platform instruction layer volume, 1:1 migration support hours, creator-reported trust erosion, and Sensing Blind Spot interval are measured before redesign begins.
■ Legal strategy function declared	The formal complaint's strategic function is documented and shared with product leadership: is it designed to change Apple's billing grammar, or to signal that the product surface is closed? These are different strategies with different product implications.

Acceptance signatures:

ROLE	NAME	SIGNATURE	DATE
Chief Executive Officer			
Chief Product Officer			
Chief Technology Officer			
Platform Operations Lead			
Legal / Policy Lead			

CLOSING STATEMENT

This artifact names the system condition that public evidence makes visible: Patreon's founding economic primitive cannot be expressed inside Apple's iOS payment grammar. Until that is named — not as a billing migration, but as a Host-Constrained Primitive Mismatch — every subsequent fix will be compensatory, and the same failure will return. The redesign is real only when the same pressure produces a different response: fan support intent yields the patronage relationship intact, without creator ghost labour, billing compression, or host recapture.

WHAT THIS DEMONSTRATES

This public diagnostic exemplar demonstrates the diagnostic logic, structural evidence tiering, governing diagnosis, and correction dependency order for a Host-Constrained Primitive Mismatch. It is not sufficient for implementation. The restricted Redesign Artifacts (Path A: The Decoupler; Path B: The Allocation Shift) contain the full replacement architecture, transition sequence, refusal invariants, recapture gates, admissibility conditions, and builder handoff. This document demonstrates the method. The Redesign Artifacts specify the implementation. The Translation Artifact makes the diagnosis and redesign accessible to non-specialist audiences.

This artifact was produced by Jamie Forrester, Independent Systems Architect, Edinburgh, UK. It is based entirely on publicly available information and was not commissioned by Patreon or Apple. The diagnostic logic, structural interpretation, and governing diagnosis are the author's own.

For the Redesign Artifacts, Redesign Executive Summary, or Translation Artifact, contact: hello@jamieforrester.com · jamieforrester.com